

Raja on the WARPATH

Congress party's second-most powerful general secretary is not averse to stirring controversy as long as it fits his leader's agenda



By Priya Sahgal

He is a man who's proved himself wrong but does not seem too unhappy about it. A decade ago, then Congress chief minister of Madhya Pradesh, Digvijay Singh had said that "a good chief minister is always a failure in Delhi politics". He cited the examples of Sharad Pawar and H.D. Deve Gowda. Ten years later, the two-term chief minister has emerged as the second-most powerful general secretary at Congress

headquarters. The first, of course, is the young scion and Digvijay's sometime protégé Rahul Gandhi. More important, his actions, however controversial, are often indicators of Rahul's agenda.

Take his recent trip to Azamgarh, a Muslim bastion in eastern Uttar Pradesh, where he sympathised with families of accused terrorists. At a loss to explain why the party general secretary was stirring communal passions, the Congress initially distanced itself from the visit with the spokesmen fobbing the media with an "ask

Digvijay". Later, it was the shrewd Thakur who had the last laugh when he revealed, "I had discussed my visit with Mr Rahul Gandhi. The Congress president was also aware of it." He added with a seemingly innocent smile, "Once they (the spokesmen) spoke to me about it, there was no confusion." Now that Rahul is contemplating a trip to Azamgarh, there's no confusion about Digvijay anymore.

"I have not asked for any judicial inquiry into the Batla House case. In fact, I told the people not to press for a judicial inquiry as they take too long.